

Mikita Brottman: The Secret Life Of Words [C1]

Nota per il suo approccio innovativo al true crime, l'autrice e psicologa fonde nelle sue opere elementi autobiografici, psicoanalisi e storia letteraria. Abbiamo parlato con lei del passato, presente e futuro della lettura.

Real life can be so much stranger and [creepier](#) than fiction, says Mikita Brottman, the British-American non-fiction author best known for her true crime novels and podcast Forensic Transmissions. Born in 1966, Brottman studied English Language and Literature in the United Kingdom, and is a certified psychoanalyst and a professor of English Literature in the United States, where she has also worked in the Maryland prison system and in forensic psychiatric [facilities](#).

HUMAN BEHAVIOUR

Her books [blend](#) autobiography, psychoanalysis, forensic psychology, and literary history. She [pieces together](#) real-life mysteries with an emphasis on human relationships and gaining a deeper understanding of human behaviour. In this approach, literature is key to her work. Yet Brottman takes a flexible view of reading, pointing out that the assumption that it is always good for us is a relatively recent one. Nor is there necessarily a progression in literature, she argues, as some older texts portray aspects of human nature that seem more relevant today than ever. And as we change as people, she says, books [come into](#) and [fade out](#) of our lives: one of her favourite novels, the 19th century book Heart of Darkness by Joseph Conrad, [grew on her](#) with time. Jove decadent (Decadent young woman, After the dance), an 1899 oil painting by artist Ramon Casas. The painting aims to capture the fin-de-siècle spirit of exhaustion and rebellion by simultaneously rooting it in intellectualism and reading.

SOLITARY VICE

In her 2008 book, *The Solitary Vice: Against Reading*, Mikita Brottman posed an unusual question: is reading really that good for you? After all, reading can be isolating. Shouldn't we spend more time talking to real people instead? And for a while, it did appear that others were thinking the same. Numerous reports claim that reading fiction is in decline and that the internet or social media or even chatbots were to blame. Yet while publishers and independent bookstores find it hard to compete with online booksellers, people are, in fact, reading more now than ever. In recent years the BBC has reported a surge in book sales, with audiobooks, radio drama, and podcasts based on books also popular. To find out more about Brottman's views on reading, we contacted the writer. We began by asking her whether reading always helps or whether it may hinder some people's interactions in the real world. **Mikita Brottman (English accent)**: I think that the general assumption is correct, that reading does help the majority of people, and it is good for children and it helps educate people and teach people about the world. Most people who read, in general, live more successful lives, earn more money and are generally happier and more successful. But historically that's not been the case. There's been lots of times when reading is seen as dangerous or difficult or problematic, or it can lead to disillusionment or rebellion. Having more knowledge is [has] not necessarily always been seen as a good thing. So I just wanted to present a historical perspective that was broader than most people were getting. But in terms of a general maxim to live by, yes, reading is probably better for you. Culture

Anna Hope: *Telling Stories To Change Things* Il genere tutto britannico del romanzo di campagna permette a questa scrittrice di affrontare numerosi temi legati all'attualità e alla storia del Regno Unito. Sarah Presant Collins , Sarah Davison

THE BIGGER PICTURE

And is social media really a threat? Brottman says that we have to look at the bigger picture. **Mikita Brottman**: There's a lot of complaints and fears about

the internet and Twitter and social media. But I think it's important to remember that around 20 per cent of the world is still illiterate. So on a world scale, people still have problems getting access to education. In terms of social media and the internet, however much people complain about that, people are still reading and writing more. If you're a kid and you're texting, you're reading and writing all day, which is something that children weren't doing in the past. It might not be ideal, but at least it's increasing literacy and encouraging literacy. Even in the US and Europe, in sophisticated countries, there are still people who don't get a good education and they don't learn to read and write.

QUALITY NOT QUANTITY

So while the internet makes books accessible, it is still up to us to choose what we want to read. Brottman says we should be open-minded yet also selective. **Mikita Brottman:** If you haven't read Shakespeare or you don't like it, it seems like there's something wrong with you, or you're not educated, or you don't understand what life is all about, or how serious it is. But I think a lot of people don't like Shakespeare and I think people should be more open about it. It's just an acquired taste. And a lot of the things that have survived have survived just because they're historically important, but they're not necessarily the best. I teach literature, so I do enjoy classic works, but I also understand the difficulties that my students have reading them, and it shouldn't be something to be embarrassed about. It should be something that you can say, "Well, maybe I'll come back to this when I'm older, when I understand it more or when my vocabulary is more advanced."

TODAY AND TOMORROW

Brottman also says that different forms of writing have different functions. Historical texts, while important, may not be well written; some books are for the moment, while others become resonant with time. **Mikita Brottman:** You need that historical perspective to understand what will last and what is going to be resonant in the future. And so there are some contemporary books that are really highly praised that I don't think are very good, but

they're just fashionable. They just [tap into](#) some current interest in racial [awareness](#) or violence or some current theme that's popular at the moment, but in fifty years, if you look at the style of the writing and the structure of the book, they're not that good. And sometimes things last just because of accident. Like a manuscript survived just because [it happened to](#) be written by a king or something, where the rest of the literature is lost. It doesn't mean it's the best, but it's historically interesting.

KEEP IT REAL

Brottman [blends](#) fiction and fact in her books. She has doubts, however, about the benefit of formulaic fantasy novels still popular with teenagers, and some adults. While they encourage the imagination, she says, they can also encourage introversion. **Mikita Brottman:** Fantasy is very, very popular at the moment. And the students are all into these [werewolves](#), vampire stories, and medieval fantasies. That can be kind of an escapism from reality and not really [engaging](#) in reality. So I think you have to [strike a balance](#). Sometimes people can become extremely introverted and have problems communicating if they spend too much time in fantasy books.

SOPHISTICATED TASTES

Exposure to different kinds of reading is key, says Brottman. We expect to fall in love with books immediately, but many work their magic slowly and require maturity to understand them. **Mikita Brottman:** If you introduce people to books that are more well [crafted](#), more [thoughtful](#), and stylistically more interesting, you can start to get people to change their taste. Just like, you know, I hated olives when I was a kid, but now I like olives. Your personality changes, your [palate](#) changes. What interests you changes a lot. And also, the more they read, the more sophisticated they become.

Glossary

- **pieces together** = ricomporre
- **surge** = aumento
- **awareness** = consapevolezza
- **it happened to** = capitato che, si dà il caso che
- **posed an unusual question** = porre una domanda
- **crafted** = realizzare
- **creepier** = più inquietante
- **thoughtful** = riflessivi
- **palate** = gusto
- **threat** = minaccia
- **encouraging** = incentivare, promuovere
- **facilities** = strutture
- **were to blame** = erano colpevoli
- **hinder** = ostacolare
- **is still up to** = dipendere da
- **blend** = mescolare
- **fade out** = svanire
- **broaden** = più ampia
- **come into** = entrare in, subentrare
- **open-minded** = aperti di mente
- **resonant** = rilevanti
- **tap into** = attingere
- **grew on her** = iniziare a piacere
- **complaints** = lamentele
- **illiterate** = analfabeta
- **embarrassed** = imbarazzati
- **praised** = elogiare
- **werewolves** = lupi mannari
- **engaging** = coinvolgere, partecipare
- **strike a balance** = trovare un equilibrio